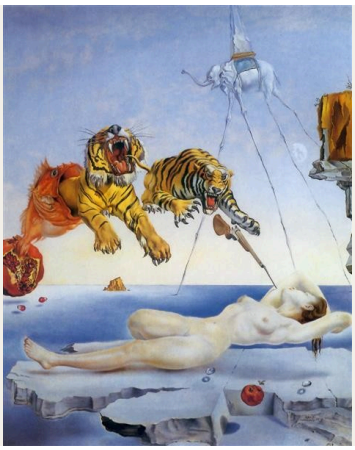
MADRID, SPAIN

Museo Nacional Thyssen-Bornemisza: Masterpieces

Twenty works build spaces that can be measured, imagined, interrupted or withheld.



Canaletto makes a square readable through perspective. Dalí gives an impossible sequence equally crisp edges. Precision, therefore, does not by itself establish whether a picture describes a plausible world. This selection follows the different agreements paintings ask the eye to accept: an upward view into an oval, a figure enclosed by branches, a city compressed between tall buildings, or bands of colour without a depicted place.

Religious figures and domestic workers provide closer comparisons. Their surroundings may be crowded with identifying objects or almost entirely removed. Ask what each work makes necessary for understanding its subject, and what it can afford to leave outside. The answer changes from one painting to the next.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/thyssen-bornemisza

The selection · 20

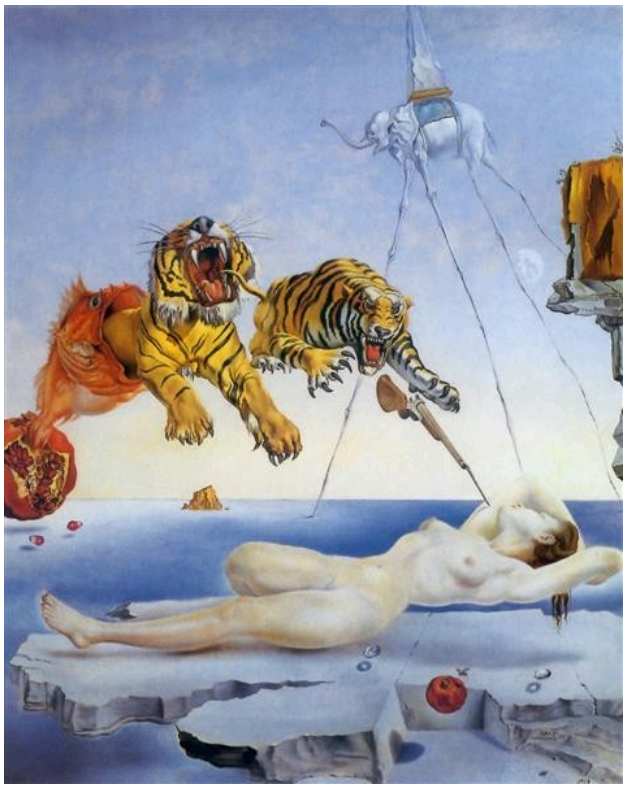
1. Dream Caused by the Flight of a Bee around a Pomegranate a Second before Awakening
   Salvador Dalí · 1947 in the current Thyssen record; c. 1944 in the Dali Foundation catalogue
2. A Bend in the River Loing in Summer
   Alfred Sisley · 1896
3. The Apotheosis of Hercules
   Giovanni Domenico Tiepolo · 1765
4. Young Knight in a Landscape
   Vittore Carpaccio · 1510
5. The Crucifixion
   Paolo Uccello · 1438
6. Christ on the Cross
   Francisco de Zurbarán · 1627
7. Easter Morning
   Caspar David Friedrich · 1835
8. The Grand Canal from Campo San Vio
   Canaletto · 1723
9. The Happy Pierrot
   Jean-Antoine Watteau · 1712
10. New York with Moon
    Georgia O'Keeffe · 1925
11. Our Lady of the Dry Tree
    Petrus Christus · c. 1450
12. Piazza San Marco Looking East
    Canaletto · c. 1723
13. Saint Catherine of Alexandria
    Caravaggio · c. 1598–99
14. Black, Red, Black
    Mark Rothko · 1968
15. The Cook
    Gabriël Metsu · c.1657 - c. 1667
16. Landscape at Dusk
    Vincent van Gogh · 1885
17. The Toilette
    François Boucher · 1742
18. The Toilet of Venus
    Peter Paul Rubens · 1608
19. The Virgin and Child
    Rogier van der Weyden · 1432
20. A Balcony, Boulevard Haussmann
    Gustave Caillebotte · 1880

01 / 20

Dream Caused by the Flight of a Bee around a Pomegranate a Second before Awakening

Salvador Dalí

1947 in the current Thyssen record; c. 1944 in the Dali Foundation catalogue · Museo Nacional Thyssen-Bornemisza



Salvador Dalí. Dream Caused by the Flight of a Bee around a Pomegranate a Second before Awakening. Image: WikiArt. Copyright protected (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Copyright protected (WikiArt label)

The fish, leaping tigers and sleeping body are individually described with clarity, yet their sequence cannot occupy ordinary physical space. Dalí makes that mismatch productive: the eye recognises each part before accepting the whole. The long title proposes the dream's cause and impending interruption. It supplies a narrative mechanism without making the impossible bodies any less precisely present.

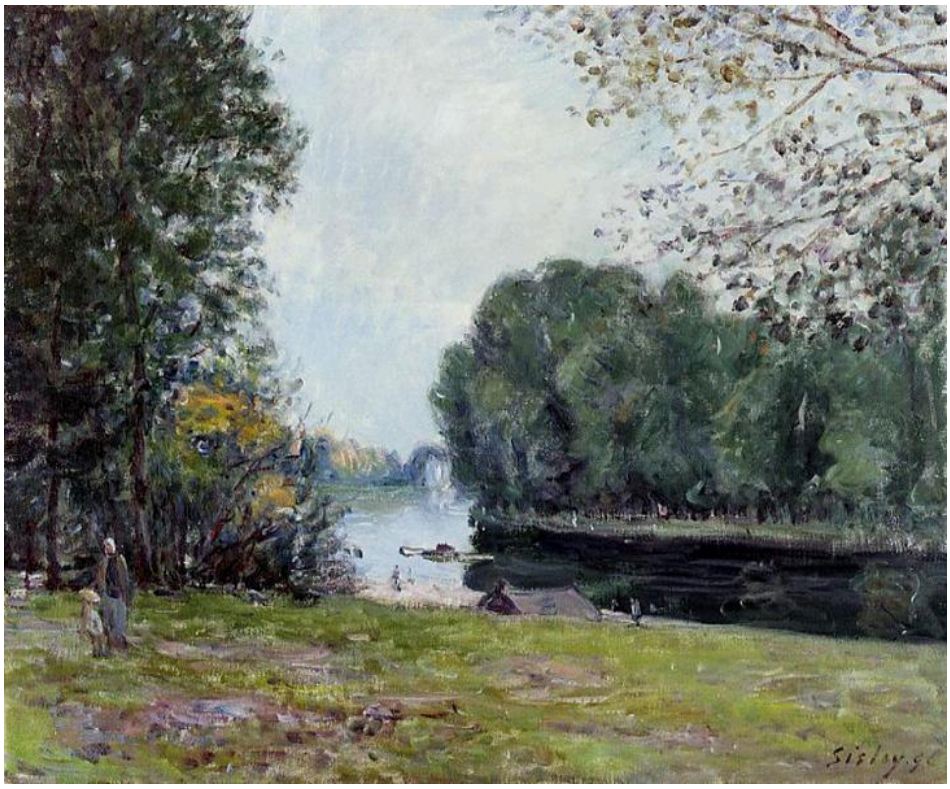
Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

A Bend in the River Loing in Summer

Alfred Sisley

1896 · Oil on canvas · Museo Nacional Thyssen-Bornemisza



A Turn of the River Loing, Summer. WikiArt; Alfred Sisley. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The river's bend carries the view beyond the near bank without revealing everything ahead. Sisley connects that route to trees, grass and changing reflected light. Small figures keep the water's edge at a human scale. The scene's coherence comes from a continuous environment, unlike the separate recognisable elements whose incompatible relations organise Dalí's dream.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

The Apotheosis of Hercules

Giovanni Domenico Tiepolo

1765 · Oil · Museo Nacional Thyssen-Bornemisza



Giovanni Domenico Tiepolo. Apotheosis of Hercules. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/giovanni-domenico-tiepolo/apotheosis-of-hercules-1765 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The oval boundary changes how the crowded assembly has to be arranged. Darker figures and clouds gather towards its edges while a brighter opening offers a direction of ascent. Giandomenico Tiepolo constructs the scene for an upward view. The bodies do not simply fill a convenient shape; their organisation depends on the position from which that shape is conceived.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Young Knight in a Landscape

Vittore Carpaccio

1510 · Museo Nacional Thyssen-Bornemisza



Vittore Carpaccio. Portrait of a Knight. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The armoured youth stands firmly while plants, animals and a mounted figure keep the surrounding landscape busy. Carpaccio combines the concentrated address of portraiture with details that encourage further interpretation. The sitter's identity and the exact meanings of those details require caution. A convincing reading should begin with their relationships, not with the assumption that every object has one settled translation.

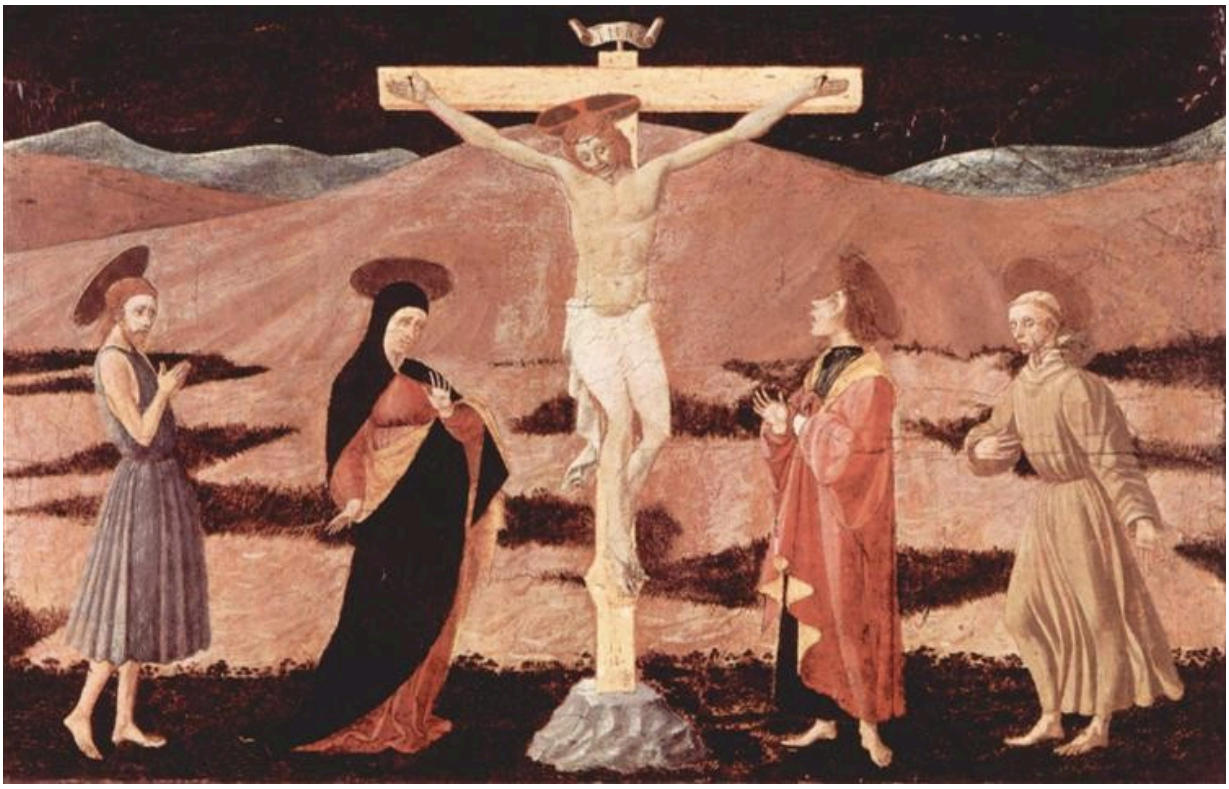
Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

The Crucifixion

Paolo Uccello

1438 · Tempera on panel · Museo Nacional Thyssen-Bornemisza



Christ on cross. WikiArt; Paolo Uccello. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The cross rises through a low, broad arrangement of mourners and simplified terrain. Uccello makes vertical and horizontal directions unusually clear within a scene of suffering. Angular hills reinforce the separation of bodies. The measured construction does not remove the subject's gravity; it gives the figures stable positions from which their relationship to the central death can be read.

Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

Christ on the Cross

Francisco de Zurbarán

1627 · Oil on canvas · Museo Nacional Thyssen-Bornemisza



Francisco de Zurbarán. Christ on the Cross. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/francisco-de-zurbaran/christ-on-the-cross-1627 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Zurbarán removes almost all the setting available in Uccello's scene. The pale body and white cloth have to carry attention against near black, with the cross supplying their support. The weight of the isolated figure becomes the principal encounter. Narrative circumstances remain understood through the subject, but they are not separately illustrated around it.

Object source · Open artwork

07 / 20

Easter Morning

Caspar David Friedrich

1835 · Oil on canvas · Museo Nacional Thyssen-Bornemisza



Easter Morning. WikiArt; Caspar David Friedrich. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Three walkers move away between bare trees under a sky that still holds the moon. Friedrich lets the title's religious association rest on a transition in light, season and movement rather than a depicted miracle. The figures give the path a use without dominating the landscape. Renewal is suggested through a world in change, not announced by a central emblem.

Object source · Open artwork

08 / 20

The Grand Canal from Campo San Vio

Canaletto

1723 · Oil on canvas · Museo Nacional Thyssen-Bornemisza



Canaletto. Grand Canal, Looking East from the Campo San Vio. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/canaletto/grand-canal-looking-east-from-the-campo-san-vio-1723 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The canal joins near steps, small boats and long palace façades within one intelligible space. Canaletto's angles establish the large structure before the individual movements on the water are followed. Different scales remain compatible: buildings can be imposing without making the boats negligible. Clear intervals let urban life occupy the same view as its architecture.

Object source · Open artwork

09 / 20

The Happy Pierrot

Jean-Antoine Watteau

1712 · Oil on canvas · Museo Nacional Thyssen-Bornemisza



Happy Pierrot. WikiArt; Jean-Antoine Watteau. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The costumed company gathers around a musician in a wooded setting rather than on a clearly bounded stage. Watteau leaves the theatrical identities active while allowing pauses and still faces to complicate the title's cheerful promise. The pale costume draws the eye, but recognition of a role does not settle the mood of the person occupying it.

Object source · Open artwork

10 / 20

New York with Moon

Georgia O'Keeffe

1925 · Oil on canvas · Museo Nacional Thyssen-Bornemisza



Georgia O'Keeffe. New York with Moon. WikiArt source label: Georgia O'Keeffe Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/georgia-o-keeffe/new-york-with-moon · Georgia O'Keeffe Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

The buildings constrain the visible sky instead of offering an open prospect of the city. O'Keeffe makes height an experience from below, with the streetlamp and a low red accent establishing nearer points of attention. Hard architectural boundaries meet softer forms overhead. The restricted view gives the picture its pressure; more information about the surrounding streets would change its purpose.

Object source · Open artwork

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Our Lady of the Dry Tree

Petrus Christus

c. 1450 · Oil on panel · Museo Nacional Thyssen-Bornemisza



Petrus Christus. Our Lady of the Dry Tree. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/petrus-christus/our-lady-of-the-dry-tree · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Bare branches form an enclosure around Mary and the child, with golden letters hanging among them. Petrus Christus joins writing, natural form and sacred presence in a compact image that does not behave like an ordinary landscape. The tree's apparent lifelessness makes the central pair more conspicuous. Its boundary directs devotion before every element's historical significance has been interpreted.

Object source · Open artwork

12 / 20

Piazza San Marco Looking East

Canaletto

c. 1723 · Oil on canvas · Museo Nacional Thyssen-Bornemisza



Canaletto. Piazza San Marco Looking East along the Central Line. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/canaletto/piazza-san-marco-looking-east-along-the-central-line · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The arcaded rows lead towards the basilica and make the square's large organisation immediately readable. Small pedestrians then break the paving into separate movements and encounters. Canaletto gives the eye two speeds: a quick grasp of the architectural space and a slower examination of its uses. The people keep the measured view from becoming an unoccupied perspective exercise.

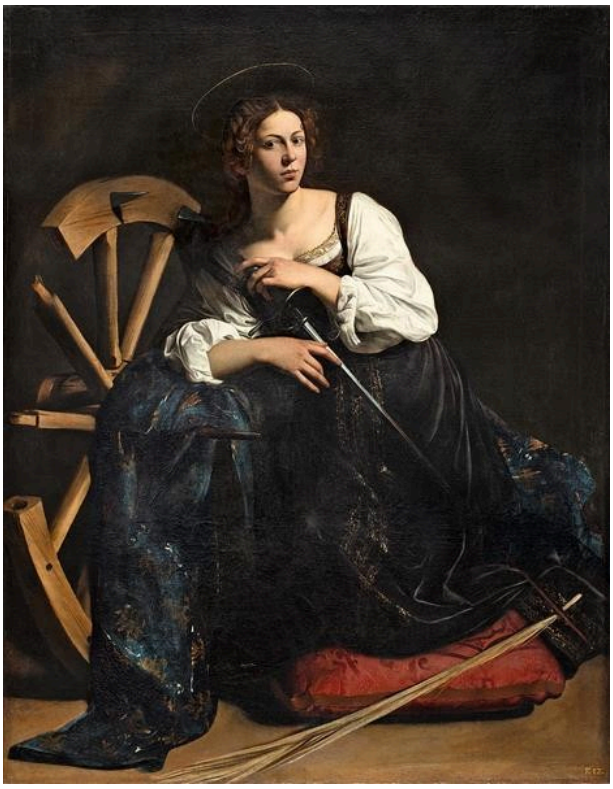
Object source · Open artwork

13 / 20

Saint Catherine of Alexandria

Caravaggio

c. 1598–99 · Oil on canvas · Museo Nacional Thyssen-Bornemisza



Caravaggio. Saint Catherine of Alexandria. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The broken wheel and sword identify Catherine through the instruments of her martyrdom, but Caravaggio shows no execution in progress. Their oblique directions gather around a kneeling woman who looks out directly. The subject is both an observed bodily presence and a set of historical-religious signs. The objects explain her identity without replacing the encounter with her face.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 81 (1934.37)

14 / 20

Black, Red, Black

Mark Rothko

1968 · Museo Nacional Thyssen-Bornemisza



Mark Rothko. Black, Red and Black. WikiArt source label: Mark Rothko Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/mark-rothko/black-red-and-black-1968 · Mark Rothko Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

The red band separates dark areas whose boundaries remain soft and uneven. Rothko makes close differences carry a structure that a quick glance may flatten into uniform black. Continued looking can disclose relationships without producing a depicted scene. The painting leaves the viewer's emotional response open; noticing its organisation does not require arriving at one prescribed state of mind.

Object source · Open artwork

15 / 20

The Cook

Gabriël Metsu

c.1657 - c. 1667 · Oil on canvas · Museo Nacional Thyssen-Bornemisza



Gabriël Metsu. The Cook. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/gabriel-metsu/the-cook · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Fish, vessels and the white-covered table make preparation materially specific. Metsu keeps the cook's face available within a setting that gives considerable attention to provisions and equipment. The room is organised around use rather than simply plenty. The worker and objects explain one another, so the interior cannot be reduced either to a portrait or to a separate still-life display.

Object source · Open artwork

16 / 20

Landscape at Dusk

Vincent van Gogh

1885 · Museo Nacional Thyssen-Bornemisza



Vincent van Gogh. Landscape at Dusk. Image credit: Vincent van Gogh. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

A narrow yellow-orange horizon holds the remaining light above rough ground and thin trees. Van Gogh lets the foreground stay uneven and subdued, giving that distant brightness greater consequence. The landscape's structure depends on what the fading day still separates. Strong colour need not occupy a large area to organise the whole view.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 788 (1966.8)

17 / 20

The Toilette

François Boucher

1742 · Oil on canvas · Museo Nacional Thyssen-Bornemisza



The Toilet. WikiArt; François Boucher. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The seated woman and the figure attending to clothing occupy a room dense with fabrics, screens and small objects. Boucher keeps their gestures readable within that abundance. Dressing connects bodies to the decorative materials around them, making the interior useful as well as elaborate. The scene's intimacy is produced through an arrangement of service, space and surfaces.

Object source · Open artwork

18 / 20

The Toilet of Venus

Peter Paul Rubens

1608 · Oil on canvas · Museo Nacional Thyssen-Bornemisza



Venus at her Toilet. WikiArt; Peter Paul Rubens. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Cupid's mirror introduces a second direction of looking beside the immediate contact between the figures. Rubens keeps the view close, with pale flesh, white fabric and small hands occupying much of it. A mythological subject takes the form of an intimate action. The mirror complicates that intimacy by making an image within the image relevant to the exchange.

Object source · Open artwork

19 / 20

The Virgin and Child

Rogier van der Weyden

1432 · Oil · Museo Nacional Thyssen-Bornemisza



Virgin and Child. WikiArt; Rogier van der Weyden. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The elaborate Gothic niche gives the pair a stone-like enclosure, while their coloured clothing and bodies resist becoming mere carved ornament. Rogier van der Weyden joins the appearance of sculpture to painted life. The architecture protects and separates at once. It defines the sacred group's place while keeping its distance from the space occupied by the viewer.

Object source · Open artwork

20 / 20

A Balcony, Boulevard Haussmann

Gustave Caillebotte

1880 · Museo Nacional Thyssen-Bornemisza



Gustave Caillebotte. Balcony, Boulevard Haussmann. Image credit: Gustave Caillebotte. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The viewer stands behind two other observers, sharing a prospect already partly occupied by their bodies and the rail. Caillebotte makes looking at the city an action inside the picture. Trees and neighbouring façades remain available, but access to the street is restricted. The balcony gives the men a position from which to see without joining the activity below.

Object source · Open artwork

Test one pictorial rule

Compare how a clear edge works in Canaletto and Dalí, or how an enclosure works around a sacred figure and a city observer. A shared device can serve different kinds of world. Current display, loans and temporary arrangements should be checked with the museum; the selection is not a fixed route through its rooms.

Further reading

Impressionism: A Centenary Exhibition

Anne Dayez, Michel Hoog and Charles S. Moffett · Read online or download · English

The catalogue offers context for Sisley, Caillebotte and the changing subjects of nineteenth-century painting. Use it alongside the older city views to compare how painters handle public space and everyday movement.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12